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DEPRESSED CLASSES AND DEMOCRATIC RIGHTS DURING THE BRITISH RAJ

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The British Government with all its colonial drawbacks, injected into Indians large doses of education based on Western philosophy, thought and science. This spread of Western education was limited and confined only to a few.¹ Bereft of social mobility, age-old traditions, back-breaking social ostracism and chill penury, the Depressed Classes were in a state of utter

ignorance in matter of even rudimentary learning. The Guntur District Magistrate wrote in 1932 that the Depressed Classes had no ideas in any matter. They were generally so much under monetary or other obligations to other classes that their participation in any social or political programme was practically nil.²

With political awakening on all sides, the Depressed Classes were also sucked into the Indian renaissance, which opened the eyes of the Hindu conservative elements for the imperative need to uplift *Panchamas* in all arenas, inclusive of education. The number of untouchable pupils in the public institutions of the Madras Presidency rose from 30 thousands to well over 1,50,000, an increase of 400% between 1892-1920.³ The government opened girls' schools for untouchables. During 1892-93, there were exclusive schools for untouchable girl students.⁴

The change in British social policy is attributed to Wood's Dispatch of 1854. Consequent to this policy, special and general schools with grant-in-aid were encouraged. It also shattered the myth of Downward Filtration Theory.⁵ In a reply dated May 20, 1857, the Count of Directors stated that no boy would be refused admission on the ground of caste, thereby throwing open the departmental schools to all communities, including the untouchable.⁶ Some headway was made in 1919 as to the admission of untouchables into all categories of schools like public schools, private schools and special schools. The public schools were totally managed by government; private schools by private individuals; some partly aided by the government; special schools were intended for untouchables, criminal tribes and aboriginals managed by the Labour Department.⁷

In 1892, the Government for the first time endeavoured to find out the progress made by the untouchables in the field of education. Statistics gathered revealed that between 1889 and 1900, the total number of untouchable students in the schools in the Madras Presidency was 52,097, among whom girls were 7,622. It was curious to know that there was a fall of boys' strength. This can be explained by the fact that the boys were weaned away from education to child-labour by their own parents, poverty being the foremost cause. The official records of the Raj reveals that by 1906-07, there were

Panchama boys, who were attending high schools and colleges. Untouchable school children began to undertake work and earn their living at an early age. To help them in the venture, half-a-day schools were inaugurated. Teachers were asked to engage one set of boys in the morning in one village and a different set in the afternoon in the neighbouring village.⁸

The improvement of literacy among untouchables made progress, though slowly and haltingly. Official records reveal that by March 1, 1919, there were on rolls 1,48,954 pupils studying in 5,242 public institutions in the Madras Presidency. Various concessions like exemption from payment of fee were granted. In this aspect, the Madras Presidency led others. Official records further reveal that in 1925-'26 there were 23 students in Arts and professional courses in Madras Presidency, whereas there were 11 in the United Provinces 14 in Bombay, 8 in the Central Province and 1 each in Bihar and Orissa. The figures, however small, reveal that Madras made advance in education among untouchables, though by 1932-'33, the position slightly altered in favour of the Bombay Presidency.⁹

In the promoting education among the untouchables the biggest problem confronting the government was the social taboo of caste Hindu pupils mixing with the untouchable children. However, the Government could slowly find feet by taking firm steps. The government as a policy laid down that none should be denied admission in public schools on grounds of caste, as the schools were maintained from the public revenue, which was intended for all classes of people in the state in the same way as Railways, Hospitals, courts of Law and other public institutions.

In spite of government orders and pious platitudes by well-intentioned persons, hurdles were still visible in the matters of admission of untouchable pupils into educational institutions. The causes for such a situation where

(1) prejudice on the part of caste Hindus, (2) situation of schools in places like *Agraharams*, where Brahmins predominantly resided, (3) objection of the building owners to rent out their premises for the location of schools, where untouchables were admitted, (4) wholesale opposition of landlords in some districts to the education of untouchables; and (5) the reluctance and lack of awareness on the part of untouchables in asserting their rights. The authorities slowly started asserting themselves against the pernicious tradition of creating hurdles in the matter of the education of the untouchables. If the caste Hindus withdrew their children, when the untouchable pupils had been admitted in schools, such vacancies would be filled up by other untouchable children, as per the ruling issued by the government in 1919.¹⁰ Government passed an order in 1919 asking the District Boards to admit pupils of Depressed Classes without any caste discriminations. A Memo was issued calling for the explanation of the Godavari District Board, when the Amalapuram Taluk Board under its jurisdiction, passed a resolution which declared admissions of untouchables in schools undesirable.¹¹ The Assistant Labour Commissioner, who was entrusted with the responsibility of *Panchama* education observed that for ages the untouchables were excluded from the pale of education, and though the English education made serious attempt to put an end to this practice in vogue in several areas, this social restriction was still observed in some rural areas. He enjoined on the teachers to admit and teach the untouchable pupils without any discrimination.¹² He warned the District and Taluk Boards that if the orders were not carried out in letter and spirit, subsidies would be withdrawn and other aids from the government cut.¹³

Municipalities in the urban areas were similarly warned. This somewhat stern action of the government resulted in the mitigation of the problem. Still, in Dharmavaram, Chandragiri, Narsapur, Gobichettipalem and Pollachchi

Taluks, the caste Hindu parents withdrew their children from schools, when they had to sit by the side of untouchable pupils. But in Andhra Districts change for the better was palpable. In Markapur, Kanigiri, Kandukur Taluks of the then Nellore District, when untouchable children had been admitted to schools, no untoward incidents took place. In Markapur, a Panchama teacher was appointed in a caste Hindu school. Schools which had been situated in temples, *Chavadis* etc., were shifted to accessible areas in the municipalities of Vizagapatam and Palghat and Local Fund areas of Bandar Taluk in the Krishna District, Kurnool and Dhone taluks in Kurnool District.¹⁴

The bitterness of caste Hindus against the admission of *Panchamas* in schools was seen gradually disappearing. However, the spread of literacy among the Depressed Classes was snail-slow, in spite of the bold steps taken by the government. In the Districts of Vizagapatam, Godavari, Guntur and Kurnool, there was a 50% increase. There were 62 schools with 2,414 boys and 34 girls in *Panchama* schools in the Godavari district by 1922.¹⁵ but, in Ganjam, Nellore and Bellary, the increase of the strength of untouchable students was not appreciable. In Anakapalli, Tenali, Narasaraopet, Hindupur, Karur and Tirupati admission of pupils belonging to untouchable communities was nil. In the Krishna District, of the 671 caste Hindu schools for boys under Taluk Boards, only in 28 schools, the children of untouchable castes were admitted.

Another bright features in the spread of education among the untouchables castes was that their children taking to the study of Sanskrit, which had been hitherto prohibited by tradition. As early as 1926, there were 35 untouchable students admitted to Sanskrit Schools and the number rose to 59 in 1928.¹⁶

E.S. Montagu, the Secretary of State for India, declaration on August 20, 1917, the process of making of Indian constitution started. In India the number of association of Indians increased,

in every branch of the administration, and the gradual development of self-governing institutions, with a view to the progressive realization of responsible government in India as an integral part of the British Empire. The Dalits had no recognized spokesperson or all-India political organization of their own. Immediately after the declaration, they were courted not only by the Indian National Congress, which sought to present itself and its views on constitutional change as representative of all Indians, but also by the newly formed Justice Party, which claimed to speak for all non-Brahmans in the Madras Presidency. The latter made its appeal to the Dalits at a public meeting in Madras on October 2, 1917 but failed to win their support.

The Congress fared somewhat better in Bombay where the Depressed Classes Mission Society organized a conference of some 2500 Dalits on November 11, 1917. This endorsed the Congress proposals for constitutional change, but at the same time asked the Government to allow Dalits to elect their own representative. The conference also called upon the Congress to pass a resolution at its forthcoming meeting "declaring to the people of India the necessity, justice, and righteousness of removing all the disabilities imposed by religion and custom upon the Depressed Classes." This the Congress did, but their victory was somewhat blunted by the resolutions of another public meeting of some 2000 Dalits, also in Bombay, held under non-Brahman sponsorship one week after the initial conference. This rejected the Congress proposals but reiterated the Dalit demand for their own representatives in the legislatures.¹⁷

The newly organized Dalit associations and public gatherings in different parts of the country responded to the Montagu declaration, Dalits at this juncture clearly had more faith in the British than in the caste Hindus (Congress of Non-Brahman) who would be the chief beneficiaries of any transfer of Power. Moreover, it was equally

clear that Dalits were more bent on establishing their own distinct political identity than in merging, and hence submerging, it into a larger non-Brahman of Indian identity. Those a few Dalits and Dalit organizations which gained access to Montagu during his trip to India in the winter of 1917-1918 and to the Southborough Commission later in 1918, testified that Dalits wanted to have their own representatives, chosen by themselves rather than by others, in the new legislatures. What the Dalits actually received in the Government of India Act of 1919 were five Government nominees in the Madras Provincial legislature; two each in the Central provinces as well as in Bihar and Orissa; one each in Bengal, Bombay, the United Provinces, and Assam; and none in the Punjab or Central legislatures. On the recommendation of the Muddiman Commission in 1924, these were doubled in Madras, the Central Provinces and Bombay, while the others remained the same and Assam lost its one nominee. In the history of India in 1927 the first Dalit, M.C. Rajah of Madras, nominated to the Central Legislative Council.¹⁸ The constitution-making process was completed in 1919, Dalits and the major political parties had very little to do with the process. Dalits participated in neither the Rowlett *Satyagraha* in 1919 nor the Non-Cooperation Movement in 1920-1922. In fact, they proved to be quite supportive of the British during the Congress boycott of the Prince of Wales' visit to India.¹⁹

Soon after coming to power in Madras, the Justice Party severed its ties with the Dalits and became a caste Hindu Party, as did the non-Brahmans in Bombay. During Non-Cooperation the Congress proved unable to get Dalit students admitted to the newly formed national schools and colleges. At Gandhi's urging it did make the removal of untouchability part of its constructive program, but did little to implement this. Gandhi's personal campaign for the removal of untouchability was blunted by his own opposition to the abolition of the caste system, a position for

which he was severely criticized not only by Dalit leaders but also by such Hindu reformers as K. Natarajan, editor of the *Indian Social Reformer*.²⁰

In 1919 the Madras government, which was considered the most progressive in this respect, appointed a Commissioner of Labour to look after Dalit interests, but his work, which got off to a good start. The Bombay government in 1923 first required schools receiving grants-in-aid not to discriminate against Dalit children, and then passed a resolution opening all public wells, watering places and *dharmsalas* to Dalits. In Mysore the Maharaja ordered government schools open to Dalits in 1919. Cochin opened its public roads and government schools in 1920, while Travancore even made some land assignments to Dalits and employed Dalits in government jobs.

The opening of public roads to Dalits might have been the biggest success of the 1920, if the provincial census commissioners of 1931 are to be believed. In other respects progress was not impressive. The government efforts in the education of Dalits, literacy rates among them remained extremely low, albeit with interesting variations. In the Punjab a mere 0.8% of Chamars were literate, while in Bihar only 0.47% of Chamars and in U.P. just 0.33% of all Dalits were. In Madras Presidency the figures were 2.2% Paraiyar, 0.8% Malas, and 0.5% Madigas. In Cochin 5.3% of the Pulayas were literate. In Travancore the Census Commissioner made comparisons by religion. Among Pulayas 4.1% of the Hindus and 13.1% of the Christians were literate, while among Paraiyar the figures were 4.9% and 15.75% respectively. Census commissioners also noted the decline of the practice of untouchability in urban areas and towards those Dalits who had left their traditional occupations. Yet in the U.P. 85.6% of all Bhangis and 87.5% of all Chamars continued in their traditional occupations, and the figures elsewhere, where recorded, were generally high. Those who were perhaps the best off were the

Mahars in the Bombay Presidency, only 17.9% of whom were reported to be continuing in their traditional occupation.²¹ Dalits enjoyed only limited access to wells and virtually no access at all to temples at the end of the decade.

During the 1920s Dalits adopted a variety of strategies to deal with the conditions under which they were forced to live. In this connection the most widespread change was in the adoption of an "Adi" name Adi-Dravida, Adi-Andhra, Adi-Karnataka, Adi-Hindu in the U.P., and Adi-Dharmi in the Punjab which indicated that they were the original inhabitants of their respective regions who had been displaced by subsequent invaders. In January 1922 the Madras Legislative Council passed a resolution changing the generic labels, Pariah and Panchama, to Adi-Dravida and Adi-Andhra²². In 1925 M.C. Rajah wrote an important book, the first of its kind by a Dalit, which gave expression to this ideology and set forth the Dalit program in the Madras Presidency.

Dalit organizations multiplied during this period. Most were quite local and even caste-specific or "Adi" in nature, but even the larger, more inclusive ones, such as B.R. Ambedkar's Depressed Classes Institute, could not claim to be fully national or representative in scope. These organizations held public meetings and conferences, invited well-known Dalits to address their gatherings, and passed resolutions in order to provide political education and build up morale among their people. Dalits also took direct action to claim their civic rights.²³

Indian Christians, like Dalits, had started to organize politically following the Government of India Act of 1909. Beginning first at the provincial level, they established the All-India Conference of Indian Christians (AICIC) in 1914. It was a small, elitist, predominantly Protestant association with some very distinguished members, modeled on the Indian National Congress of the Pre-Gandhian Era and quite close to the National Liberal Federation in political

outlook. Its basic purpose was "to bring the various [regional Indian Christian] Associations into touch with one another, to discuss matters of common interest to the community and adopt measures to promote its welfare and to represent to the Government the needs and grievances of Indian Christians." At the time of Montagu's visit to India in 1917 - 18 it had petitioned him to allocate seats to representatives of the Indian Christian community in the central and provincial councils.²⁴ Their representation to the Southborough Commission was more specific: 6 seats in the Madras Council, 2 in each of the other provincial councils and one in the central legislative council. In justifying this allocation they cited the following significant reasons, in addition to the rapidly increasing numbers and high literacy rate of the Indian Christian community.

The appointment of the Simon Commission stimulated considerable political activity by Dalit organizations. they presented memoranda or appeared before the Simon Commission and had summarized their demands as follows: (i) the grant of effective and adequate representation to the untouchables in the provincial and central legislatures and in the various local self-governing bodies such as the panchayats, taluka boards, union boards, district boards, municipalities; (ii) the provision for their representation in the ministries and the Executive Councils of the Governors and the Viceroy; (iii) the extension of franchise; (iv) the necessity of political safeguards and statutory guarantees with regard to the proper and adequate arrangement of their education, their recruitment in civil and military services, and the unrestricted enjoyment of the civil rights.

Dr. B R Ambedkar and the Depressed Classes Institute in Bombay considered Dalits to be a distinct minority, separate from the Hindu community. They also wanted to receive reserved seats in a general electorate provided an adult franchise was granted. If it were not, then

separate electorates would necessary. On the other hand, M.C. Rajah and the All-India Adi Dravida Maha Jana Sabha in Madras did not draw as sharp a line separating Dalits from caste Hindus, and downplayed caste divisions among Dalit sub-castes. They also advocated separate electorates as well as a combination of election and nomination in order to get "the best" representatives for the Dalits and insisted that only Dalits, rather than interested or concerned members of other communities, be allowed to represent Dalits.²⁵

The All-India Adi Dravida Mahajana Sabha and Madras Arundhati Mahajana Sabha were in basic agreement. In their view, a Dalit upon conversion ceases to be untouchable and "becomes a touchable" even in the eyes of caste Hindus. They also denied that the same differences between caste and non-caste Christians prevail as among caste and non-caste Hindus. On the other hand, the Dalit Christian deputation considered their Dalit identity primary, fir Christian Dalits live side by side with Hindu Dalits and are treated as Dalits by caste Hindus and caste Christians alike. Both were Depressed Classes and religion was not a criterion.

In July 1928 the drafting committee headed by Motilal Nehru recommended in its report to the All-Parties Conference that there be no separate electorates and that only Muslims be granted reserved seats. For the Dalits they offered no political safeguards, but an adult franchise, a declaration of rights, and special educational benefits instead. The Christian leadership, while concerned about safeguarding minority interests, was in general agreement with these recommendations, where as the Dalit leadership definitely was not. The Simon Commission, which worked more slowly and issued its report only in May 1930, granted separate electorates to various minorities, including Christians. After noting that most of the Dalit deputations it met had favored separate electorates, it nonetheless

recommended that the Dalits have reserved seats in the general constituency in proportion to three-quarters of their population ratio and that in special cases Governors could nominate non-Dalits to represent them.²⁶ However, by the time these recommendations were published, the political situation had changed considerably and so they carried little weight.

The Round Table Conference recommended by the Simon Commission. This met in London from November 11, 1930 to January 19, 1931. The First Round Table Conference was an important milestone in the history of the Dalit movement, for it conferred upon Dalits the political recognition they had been seeking.²⁷ The second session of the Round Table Conference met in London from September 7 to December 1, 1931. Prior to leaving for London Gandhi had indicated that he would recognize only the Muslims and Sikhs, but not the Christians or the Dalits as separate entities. Ambedkar, on the other hand, shared with the British the view that India was made up of diverse groups, each of which needed its own representatives.

No attempt was made to work through these differences or to find a mutually acceptable solution. Gandhi offered the Dalits little except "trust me" or "trust Congress"; he did not even endorse Ambedkar's earlier position of reserved seats within joint electorates.²⁸ Instead he sought to present himself and the Congress as the authentic representative of "the vast mass of the Untouchables," first by claiming that he and Congress shared this with Ambedkar and Srinivasan; then by questioning in the Minorities Committee whether the other delegates, all nominated by the Government, in fact represented the views of their respective communities; and finally by asserting, after publication of the Minorities Pact which called for separate electorates, that "I would get, if there was a referendum of the Untouchables, their vote, and that I would top the poll."²⁸ To all of this Ambedkar took exception. In the end the Conference adjourned and left the Prime Minister to make a decision on the communal question.

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